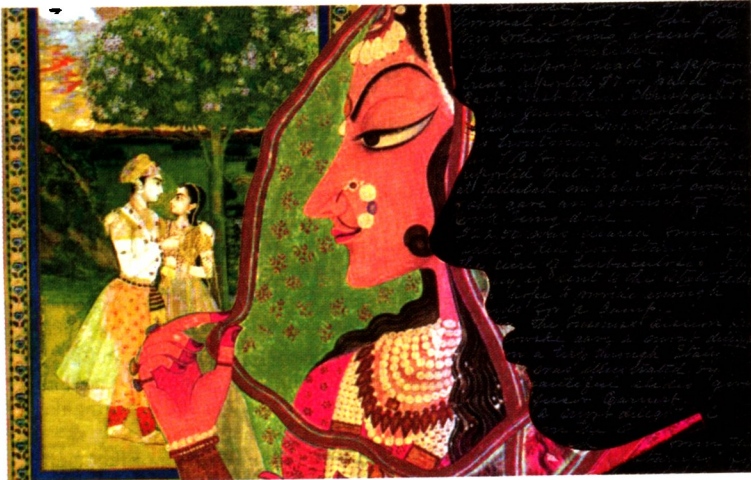


There are, however, some glaring omissions—perplexing for a work so thorough that reading the footnotes becomes a chore. The death, in saddle, of General Asif Nawaz Janjua finds no mention in the context of Islamabad. Nor does India's success in impounding Ku Wol San, the North Korean ship carrying proliferation contraband while the neighbours fought over Kargil, or the last global nuclear flashpoint. Operation Parakram.

What is not omitted is the facilitation of Pakistan's proliferation activities by the US. All presidents since Jimmy Carter looked the other way for the sake of short-term interests. If it was the Soviets in 1979, in 2001 it was Osama bin Laden who made the Executive lie to its Legislature, and its people. In be-

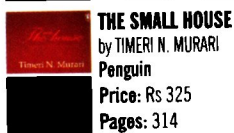


tween, it was the sheer avarice of Chinese contracts that prevented president Bill Clinton from coming down hard on both. So much so that "Musharraf's aides laughed when they read the text of Bush's speech. One recalled: 'We are back in the old relationship, you know the one, where we do as we please, and they do as we please.'" Which begs the question, why do the Pakistanis do what they do? The answer comes, succinctly enough, from an Indian columnist, "Screw India".



Twist in the Fairytale

Set in an intriguing backdrop of royal history, this is a story of an heiress to a lost kingdom and her unfaithful industrialist-husband



■ By Sonya Dutta Choudhury

A poor princess married to a handsome millionaire, has a nice, modern, fairytale ring to it; how much more power couple can you get? But Roopmati, impoverished heiress to the lost kingdom of Krishnarangam, is not happy. Bartered in marriage to industrialist Khri Malhotra, she retreats into a melancholy study of history, walking the lonely rooms of Malhotra's Madras mansion by day, and dreaming of her namesake, the beautiful Rupmati who was kept by the emperor Baz Bahadur, by night. When she's not silently signing business papers for Malhotra, who has moulded his myriad businesses around the Mati brand ("She's my good luck charm," he explains), she writes papers on ancient Chola history, moons over her mysteriously missing brother Tommy, and hangs out occasionally with her filmmaker-friend Tazneem.

Yet action is all set to implode on this zombied and placidly unhappy front. Tazneem and then Roopmati discover

their husbands are being unfaithful to them. Events unfold, Sidney Sheldon-like, with much sex, scandal and intrigue. Tazneem's handsome husband Hari has a secret life, including a liaison with a gay filmstar, and Malhotra stashes away an ambitious mistress in the *chinnawheedu* or the small house. All rather page-3, but pleasantly so. Murari has an eye for detail, for conversation and for character, and his protagonists, including even peripheral ones like Roopmati's dissolute and drunk father are drawn true-to-life. As are some episodes, like the cocktail party for Mr Schneider or Hari's trip to the temple at Tirupati.

And then there's the history. Murari has always had a nice sense of it (his *Taj*, a sumptuous story of the building of the Taj Mahal, offers a racy ringside view of the construction). It's this sense of history that comes out tops again, setting up an intriguing backdrop to the story of *The Small House*. Yes, indeed, this is how the hangover of royal history may debilitate a family into debt and dissolution, and this is also how mere millions may not buy it back. That said, Murari does try for a happy resolution in an all-the-actors-come-together climax at *chinnawheedu*. Accept your past, the author-historian says, and only then can you move on.